

Back in play: Paul Pogba returns to mainstream action for Monaco after having served a doping ban since 2023. AFP

to Naples. Last season, his dynamic presence in midfield along with his 12 goals earned him the Serie A MVP award. As for Chivu, it will be a trial by fire. Stepping up to manage the club he once played for, he will constantly be in the radar of critics, many of whom feel he is not ready for such a high-profile job.

Italian clubs have been fairly quiet in the transfer market so far, with no truly headline-grabbing deals. Inter's signing of Brazilian forward Luis Henrique from Marseille remains the league's most expensive move.

AC Milan, which last won the Scudetto in the 2021-22 season to break an 11-year drought, has struggled to keep pace with its top-tier counterparts.

Last season it finished eighth, and although the Rossoneri will enjoy a touch of midfield magic from Modric, who joined on a free transfer,

the chances of toppling Napoli and Inter appear far-fetched.

It's all about Paris

Since the financial injection from the Qataris, Paris Saint-Germain has almost made the Ligue 1 trophy its own. Since the 2012-13 season, the Paris club has won the league 11 times in 13 seasons.

Heading into the new campaign, it is hard to see the narrative changing — PSG remains the clear favourites.

Under Luis Enrique, it finally lifted its Champions League curse, winning the title for the first time in its history after beating Inter in the final, though it lost to Chelsea in the FIFA Club World Cup final.

PSG will have a new neighbour in the French top flight after Paris FC's promotion this season, setting up a derby between two clubs whose stadiums are separated by nothing more than a single street — the Rue Claude Farrere.

Meanwhile, Monaco fans are caught between excitement and uncertainty after the club signed Paul Pogba on a free transfer.

Having last played professional football in 2023, after which he served a doping ban, there are doubts about the player's ability to readjust to the top level.

However, given Pogba's flair and natural ability, Monaco will have an excellent midfielder if he clicks.

The club will also have an experienced defender in Eric Dier, who also arrived on a free transfer.



Top buys

Premier League

Florian Wirtz (£100m) — Bayern Leverkusen to Liverpool

Hugo Ekitike (£69m) — Eintracht Frankfurt to Liverpool

Benjamin Sesko (£66.3m) — RB Leipzig to Manchester United

Bryan Mbeumo (£65m) — Brentford to Manchester United

Matheus Cunha (£62.5m) — Wolverhampton Wanderers to Manchester United

La Liga

Dean Huijsen (£50m) — AFC Bournemouth to Real Madrid

Alex Baena (£43.4m) — Villarreal to Alex Baena

Alvaro Carreras (£42m) — Benfica to Real Madrid

Franco Mastantuono (£38.5m) — River Plate to Real Madrid

Dávid Hancko (£26m) — Feyenoord to Atletico Madrid

Bundesliga

Luis Diaz (£65.5m) — Liverpool to Bayern Munich

Jobe Bellingham (£32m) — Sunderland to Borussia Dortmund

Jarell Quansah (£30m) — Liverpool to Bayer Leverkusen

Serie A

Luis Henrique (£31.5m) — Marseille to Inter Milan

Francisco Conceicao (£27.3m) — Porto to Juventus

Wesley França (£25m) — Flamengo to Roma

Jesus Rodriguez (£19.2m) — Real Betis to Como

Ligue 1

Igor Paixao (£34.2m) — Feyenoord to Marseille

Lucas Chevalier (£33.8m) — Lille to Paris Saint-Germain

(All figures are initial amounts; Data updated as of August 9)

